

SYED ALI

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Senior MEL and Data Systems Specialist with 12+ years designing and implementing monitoring, evaluation, and learning frameworks, data infrastructure, and analytics solutions across international development, public sector, and nonprofit environments. Proven track record managing programs funded by Global Fund, USAID, DFID, UNAIDS, BHC, EKN, and UNDP. Technical depth in Python, SQL, Tableau, and cloud platforms, complemented by expertise in mixed-method evaluation, theory of change development, democratic governance, and AI-driven workflow automation. US-based with extensive Southeast Asia, South Asia, and Bay Area experience.

CORE COMPETENCIES

MEL & Evaluation: Theory of Change, Log Frame Design, Results-Based Management, Impact Assessment, Mixed-Methods Evaluation, Dedoose, Outcome Harvesting, MERLA Frameworks

Data & Analytics: Python, SQL, R, Tableau, Power BI, Excel, Salesforce, HMIS, PostgreSQL, MySQL

Program Management: Multi-donor Program Coordination, Grant Compliance, Stakeholder Engagement, PMP Certified

AI & Automation: RAG Pipelines, n8n, Zapier, Scikit-Learn, Workflow Automation

Domain Expertise: Democratic Governance, Voice & Accountability, Health Systems, WASH, Economic Mobility, Social Protection

GIS: ArcGIS Pro, ArcGIS Online, GeoPandas

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Data Engineer | [SCI](#) | Remote / Bay Area, CA

Feb 2026 – Present

- Design and maintain robust data pipelines to ingest and process weather, satellite, and IoT data from multiple sources for farmer advisory systems
- Architect and manage scalable cloud-based data infrastructure including data lakes and warehouses on AWS
- Develop real-time and batch processing solutions delivering timely weather alerts and decision-support insights to agricultural communities
- Ensure data quality, governance, and reliability while collaborating with agronomists, climate experts, and product teams

Senior Research Analyst | [JobTrain Inc.](#) | Menlo Park, CA

Dec 2024 – Jan 2026

- Designed and built scalable in-house data warehouse consolidating multiple data sources into a unified reporting infrastructure, reducing quarterly reporting time from 3 days to under 4 hours
- Collaborated with Santa Clara County partners, extracting and analyzing HUD and VI-SPDAT data from California's Homeless Management Information System (HMIS) to support cross-agency program planning and compliance reporting
- Contributed to adoption and implementation of the EMPATH economic mobility framework, building data systems that tracked participant progression from skill development to financial stability
- Evaluated and redesigned IT, Construction and Building Trades, and Certified Nursing Assistant (CNA) skill development programs, identifying curriculum alignment gaps and developing evidence-based recommendations that improved credential attainment and employment rates
- Built automated Tableau dashboards and Python pipelines providing real-time performance visibility, with n8n workflow triggers flagging data quality issues at point of entry
- Established data governance standards and trained staff on new systems, eliminating data inconsistencies across 5+ funding streams

Data Analyst | [Direct Adverts Media](#) | New York, NY

Mar 2021 – Dec 2023

- Led data integration and modeling for marketing performance analytics, improving reporting efficiency by 50%
- Built predictive models and segmentation frameworks using Python and Scikit-Learn to optimize ad spending, resulting in 30% ROI growth and 15% increase in click-through rate

- Designed and implemented A/B testing frameworks and machine learning-driven ad delivery, driving 12% sales lift
- Established data quality governance standards, reducing reporting errors by 40% and saving 20+ hours per week in manual reporting tasks

Independent MEL Consultant | [BISP \(Benazir Income Support Programme\)](#) | Pakistan Jan 2021 – Dec 2024

Concurrent part-time consultancy alongside full-time employment

- Designed and operationalized national-level MEL frameworks for social safety net programs serving 27 million households implemented by 80 grantees
- Implemented centralized dashboards for Flood Relief Cash Transfer (120,000 households) and Benazir Talemi Wazaif (250,000 students), introducing automation in reporting processes
- Developed MERLA-driven project proposals for multi-sector nutrition programs funded by USAID, incorporating advanced measurement frameworks
- Facilitated Theory of Change workshops and designed strategic learning agendas for continuous improvement in program delivery

Monitoring, Evaluation and Research Manager | [Plan International UK](#) | Bangladesh & Pakistan Jul 2016 – Dec 2020

- Designed and operationalized program-wide data collection and analytics frameworks for the South Asia WASH Results Program (DFID-funded), translating MEL requirements into structured datasets, indicators, and reporting schemas across consortium partners
- Led data aggregation, validation, and consolidation workflows producing monthly, semiannual, and annual analytical reports tracking performance against results frameworks
- Developed standardized digital data collection tools and reporting templates enabling consistent field-level monitoring data ingestion across multiple geographies
- Managed the Accelerating Sexual and Reproductive Health Services program across Southeast Asia engaging 40+ professionals, government partners, and civil society organizations

M&E Specialist | [World Bank – Social Protection and Labor Wing](#) | Pakistan Aug 2015 – Jun 2017

- Designed data-driven monitoring systems for a \$150M social protection program, improving performance tracking across 42 districts
- Implemented baseline surveys, rapid market assessments, and analytics frameworks to support evidence-based policy design
- Introduced data visualization and reporting tools for real-time decision-making by senior government and World Bank teams

Head of Monitoring, Evaluation & Reporting | [Strengthening Participatory Organizations \(SPO\)](#) | Pakistan Aug 2012 – Jul 2015

- Built and deployed a fully automated MIS for large-scale DFID- and BHC-funded programs (\$77M combined), streamlining reporting across 52 districts
- Led implementation of DFID-funded AWAZ Voice and Accountability Program, FCO-funded Strengthening Civil Society to Address Conflicts Program, and USAID/NDI Political Party Development Program
- Engaged directly with political parties around community social issues, facilitating research-backed dialogue between party leadership and marginalized communities on health, housing, gender equity, and civic participation
- Conducted national and provincial surveys including Individual Philanthropy Survey in Pakistan and Research on Family Foundations in Pakistan
- Designed impact evaluation frameworks integrating real-time dashboards for donor and program reporting

CERTIFICATIONS

- Databricks Certified Data Engineer Professional
- Microsoft Certified: Azure Administrator Associate
- Project Management Professional (PMP) — PMI, USA, 2023
- Tableau Desktop Specialist — Salesforce, 2023
- Google Data Analytics — Coursera

EDUCATION

SELECTED PUBLICATIONS

Individual Philanthropy in Punjab (2011) | Family Foundations in Punjab (2010) | Corporate Philanthropy Surveys (2007–2009) — Pakistan Centre for Philanthropy

Counting the Invisible – Technical Report (2017) — Plan International Pakistan